

CRAFTING A WIN
Rahul with sister Priyanka and mum Sonia in Rae Bareli, May 18

ANI

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that, both have recalibrated their caste calculus, incorporating inclusive elements in it. RJD leader Tejaswi Yadav carefully stuck to universalist themes like unemployment, and won Bihar's highest individual party vote share—even if for only four seats. The SP in UP reactivated its PDA—Pichhda (backward), Dalit and Alpasankhyak (minorities) plan. The alliance with Congress in both states ensured the least fragmentation of non-BJP votes (and also enabled the Dalit vote shift). Consequently, the NDA tally in Bihar was trimmed to 30 from 39 and in UP to a morale-crushing 36 from 64.

Then, there was the minority question. In the run up to the Lok Sabha polls, it became clear that the minorities, especially the Muslims, would for the first time vote with one goal—to defeat the BJP. Besides UP and Bihar, where the NDA suffered heavy losses, this consolidation helped Trinamool Congress chief and West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee increase her tally from 22 to 29 in a state where the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019, became a polarising issue. The Christians in the Northeast likewise consolidated around non-NDA parties following the ethnic violence in Manipur. The Congress ended up being the immediate beneficiary, winning both seats in Manipur, the one seat in neighbouring Nagaland (after two decades) and Tura in Meghalaya (since 1998). This still leaves it open to BJP invectives. Already, in Assam, CM Himanta Biswa Sarma has called the state results proof of Congress 'minoritarianism'—Muslims number over 60 per cent in two of the three seats the party won. But that it routed AIUDF chief Badruddin Ajmal in Dhubri also speaks of mainstreaming. And the marquee fight was won by Gaurav Gogoi in Jorhat, where Muslims are below seven per cent.

AN UNFINISHED YATRA

While INDIA's social engineering around economic distress and social inequity trimmed the BJP's tally, the latter is still way ahead. INDIA's total MPs put together still number eight less than the BJP's individual tally. The future of some alliances, such as between the Aam Aadmi Party and the Congress in Delhi and elsewhere, is now shaky. The Congress was accused of playing big brother in INDIA even when it had just 52 MPs. Now, as the leading party in the alliance by a fair margin, the GOP must shoulder more responsibility to keep the alliance together not just to win future elections but also to hold the ruling party to account inside and outside of Parliament.

And while the Congress, now the second largest party in the country, may have improved its score in direct fights against the BJP in several states, including Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan and Haryana, it cannot ignore the ignominy of scoring a duck in three states that account for 38 seats—MP, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh (where it won the assembly polls last year). In Gujarat and Chhattisgarh, it won just two of 35 seats. Indeed, in Karnataka and Telangana, both post-BJY conquests that were much ballyhooed, it won just only 17 of 45 seats. "The Congress has failed to develop a state as a model to market for electoral gains," says a party Rajya Sabha MP. "The Gujarat model has holes, but Modi successfully sold it to the masses. It gave people the confidence that his government will deliver."

The BJP remains strong against the Congress in a majority of its bastions and unless the GOP strengthens itself in these states, the allies may not allow it to benefit from their support in states where it is the junior partner. The challenge of 2014 persists for Rahul in 2024—to rebuild the Congress organisation in states such as UP, Bihar, West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and make it a winning unit in states such as MP, Gujarat and Maharashtra. The party's future also depends on whether its inroads in Rajasthan, Haryana and Karnataka can be converted into bigger gateways. ■